

Paranoid about security flaws? We'll show you how to stay informed, and keep your system as secure as possible

Silhouetted against the glow of a monitor in a dark basement, typing away furiously at a keyboard, an anonymous rebellious-looking figure is plotting to take over the world... that's how hackers are depicted in movies. Reality is quite different. Today, it's all about fortune and fame. Before you can say "Digit", your system has been broken into, your files accessed and malicious remote control code installed. Hackers are on the lookout for anything to help them make money, or a name for themselves—stealing your credit card numbers, your passwords and using you as a mask to propagate spam.

Security is hogging the limelight, thanks to the Blaster and SoBig worms. The latest breed of viruses are emulating their real-life counterparts—they are stealthy, fast reproducing and powerful.

"Why would anybody want to hack my computer?", you ask. "I have nothing they would want, I don't even have a credit card." Think of your PC as a digital version of your home. Carelessness on your part could put your entire family and friends at risk. If you're infected, chances are that the worm will send itself to all e-mail addresses in your address book. Your friends and family will open the e-mail without suspicion,

thinking you finally decided to be sociable and write. That's when all hell will break loose; prepare to be ignored and hated, for a while at least.

Just like the doors and windows of your home, your system too has various avenues of entry—each one needs to be guarded using anti-virus software, firewalls, etc. Naive, paranoid, or somewhere in between, no level of security that you choose will ever be 100 per cent secure; but whatever lets you sleep peacefully at night, is what you need.

Another alternative is to use proxy servers, such as www.idzap.com or www.anonymizer.com. These proxy servers allow you to surf freely without anyone detecting your presence online.

You also need to thoroughly search for vulnerabilities in your system and patch them. Of course, you can't learn every programming language out there, and then take apart programs to find flaws—luckily for you, there are already people who do this for a living; all you need to do is stay informed so that you can take appropriate action as and when required.

Patch before hack

Often, a software company finds a vulnerability before hackers do, and even

releases a patch, but people are too slow to patch-up. The best example is the infamous Blaster worm: Microsoft announced a security patch on 16 July, 2003, but Blaster only surfaced on 11 August, 2003. If the majority had updated their PCs within the first month of the patch release, Blaster would have failed miserably. The real challenge is protecting against flaws that hackers discover before security companies do. The easiest way to minimise the effect of this is to encrypt your data and back it up.

First stop

You need to keep checking the official Web sites first. Windows users ought to keep an eye on the official Microsoft security Web site (www.microsoft.com/security), which gives comprehensive information on security-related issues with Microsoft products. The company issues security bulletins that list the vulnerabilities discovered, and a link to the patch. Below the bulletin is a list of the latest viruses discovered, with an indication of the level of threat posed by it.

Another option is to subscribe to the Microsoft security bulletin, and get updates via e-mail. To opt for this, go to the security home page, click on 'E-mail Notification' and enter your e-mail address. If you have an always-on Internet connection, and run Windows 2000 and above, you can use the Automatic Update feature for hassle-free updates. Go to **Start > Settings > Control Panel > Automatic Updates** and enable the Automatic Update feature. You can also visit <http://windowsupdate.microsoft.com> and do an online scan of your system, to find missing updates and patches.

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